GEOFF

THE BALCONY DOG

Congratulations on welcoming a furry friend into your home! To help you get started, here's a friendly guide packed tips and advice from when I welcomed Geoff home.

Before your dog arrives:
Safe Space: Create a cozy, safe area for your dog to relax. When Geoff first arrived he went straight into my bedroo to hide, so be mindful of what spot this is as it will likely be their spot for the next 24 hours +.
Dog-Proofing: Put away anything that could be dangerous or tempting for your dog to chew on.
Supplies: Make sure you have all the essentials—food, water bowls, treats, a comfy bed, toys, a leash, and collar.
Apartment Essentials: More puppy pads than you think you need, dog wet wipes (you can buy these from Amazon or poundland, poo bags, pet friendly disinfectant, carpet cleaner**, rubber gloves, old rags/cloths.

When Geoff first arrived he was terrified, for the first day he wouldn't leave my bedroom and he pooed/peed all over the place. If you can, keep any room with carpet off limits as soon as they enter the flat for the first time.

Day 1:
As soon as Geoff came into my building he refused to get into the lift. This is something that I had never considered and I had to carry him up the stairs but please consider how terrifying the new building/noises/lights and smells will be at this point, as well as how scary you are to your new dog at this point.

Once in the flat Geoff ran away from me as quick as he could and hid in the quickest place he could find. I let him decompress for as long as it took until he made his way into the room I was in and had some water. At this point he had no interest in food and spent a lot of time figuering out his new home. I left the balcony door open for him and let him find his way out there when he felt comfortable doing so. Due to his fear Geoff would only toilet inside and refused to leave the the flat and this continued for 3 days so be prepared for this. The first night was the hardest, I was awake through the night as Geoff was restless. I would advise leaving your dog in a room away from you to continue to decompress.

Day 2 - 5:
Geoff found the idea of leaving the flat terrifying and chose only to toilet in the house. This is where the real challenge started!

I spent a lot of time trying to coax Geoff through the front door for a walk, I tried chicken, sausage, cheese, anything I getmy hands on and bit by bit I would get him closer to the door of the stairwell to my flat. Street dogs are clever! It's not as east as you think! By day 4 we had reached the stairs and a new fear was unlocked. Que more sausage and plenty more days of pleading with him to get down the stairs, nothing would convince him so by day 5 I picked him up and carried him down. I blame this mainly on my own fear, so try not to be scared of aggression as this is something I regret. He would of been out walking much sooner if I'd pulled myself together and carried him.

Once out the front door.. he never used the flat as a toilet again!

Day 5-10:
Over next week we started our regular morning, afternoon and evening walks. This is a really good time to desensitise your dog to the area and to your building. I continued with the treats and gave Geoff a break from any new stressors, so avoiding the lift and continued to carry him up and down the stairs until he was confident using them himself. Slowly he became familliar with the stairs and finally started using them without my help.

By now Geoff'd stomach had settled from the journey to the UK and I found him becoming more and more animated and relaxed. He would spend time laying down to my side whilst I sat on the sofa and started to play with toys.

I then started to take him to more populated places and taking him further afield on walks.

Day 10 onwards:
Slowly you begin to understand when your dog needs to go for the toilet but I advise on following a regular toileting pattern for atleast 6 months. I would take Geoff at 9am, 1pm, 6.30pm & 10pm. As time has gone on I've come to realise this dog loves a lie in and is more happy curled up in bed in the morning than going for a walk (maybe I lucked out) but I think as long as he has his toilet breaks and one good walk a day... he's happy! I say this as I felt like there was a lot of pressure at the beginning, with living in a flat to take him out through fear of him suffering in silence, so just take some time to understand their needs and in time they will also let you know when they need to go.

GOOD LUCK!